take the Mughals into deeper defiles. The best they could make of this bad situation was to remain where they were, and try to defuse the Afghan onslaught.

Again, the two inexperienced commanders ‘stuck to their own opinions’. Four days later, the Mughals were marching once more; Birbar and Abul Fath in front, Zain fighting off Afghans in the rear. It was thus that Zain discovered only too late that his two colleagues had called a halt in a defile, vulnerable to assaults from a height further on. It was already late, Afghans were ‘pressing on them from behind’, so Zain Khan did the best he could: he ordered a vanguard to march ahead and take over the tactical height, while he turned back to keep the encroaching Afghans at bay.

Chaos fell upon the Mughal camp as he left. The vanguard’s resumption of its march confused everyone, more and more Afghans began to attack from all sides, and the Mughal troops rushed ahead pell-mell, not knowing they were going into even lower ground. It was to this scene of stampede and panic – ‘elephants, horses and men . . . mixed up’ – that Zain returned. He had escaped the Afghans when they took a break to count their plunder.

Night had fallen when Zain rode back into the main camp; and in the anxious dark, some Mughal soldiers mistook their commander’s arrival for a fresh attack by the enemy: ‘Foolish babblers called out that the Afghans are coming after us!’

Fortunately, the rumour was quickly quashed, but the cold night was spent in fear. Dawn brought no relief. Instead, Afghans appeared on the heights around them, ‘like ants and locusts, from all sides of the mountains’.[23] The Mughal soldiers were like fish in a bowl to their enemy, who ‘showered . . . stones and arrows [upon them] like rain’.[24]

It was a debacle; the worst defeat that the Mughals had sustained under Akbar’s ever-victorious reign. Historians of the time estimate that between 500 and 8000 men were killed.[25] But the emperor counted only one man’s death. Birbar did not survive the massacre.

Akbar was devastated. For two days and nights after news of the disaster arrived, Akbar wouldn’t eat or drink; it was his mother, Hamida, who finally made him. His ‘heart turned away from everything’, writes Abul Fazl. Akbar himself wrote to Abdur Rahim, telling him of the tragedy. ‘[T]he memory of the pleasures of his lofty company has become very